I didn’t play on the three-Test tour, even when Andrew Strauss went home before the final match to attend the birth of his son Sam, but I was integrated immediately into the group. I might have been the rookie, in my first team meeting, but they wanted my insight into my Essex teammate Danish Kaneria, the right-arm leg-spinner who would eventually be banned for life for spot fixing.

Sport reflects the brittleness and uncertainty of life. I’ve never asked Marcus Trescothick about the illness which resulted in his departure from the 2006 tour of India and my unlikely Test debut. Our conversations tend to centre on the future, in the form of his coaching ambitions, rather than the past. I suppose it reflects the unspoken reality that one man’s misfortune is another’s opportunity.

When he returned home, citing a virus as a diversion from the terrors of what would eventually be diagnosed as clinical depression, I was on an England Lions tour of the West Indies. I’d scored 6 in the first innings of the initial unofficial Test at the Recreation Ground in Antigua when I received a tap on the shoulder from Peter Moores, our coach.

‘Go and pack your bags. You and Jimmy are being called up to go and play in India.’

I’d never heard of Nagpur, our destination, and frankly dreaded the journey because Jimmy had abused me a fair old bit the previous September, when I got the treatment from the entire Lancashire team in a County Championship match at Chelmsford. I’d scored a double hundred against the Australians the previous week, and they informed me I was a posh boy who was ‘strutting around’.

A bit harsh, and not entirely fair, but Jimmy gave me a particularly pungent send-off when he had me caught by Andrew Symonds for 19 in the second innings, after I’d made 64 first up. The memory was with me as we commandeered the team bus and headed to the beach, since we had time to kill before the evening flight.

We’d barely spoken on the tour and lay there, half pretending we were asleep. I thought I’d better break the ice, since we were about to fly halfway around the world and would spend the first seven hours of a two-day journey cooped up together in cattle class, on the way to London. It was a strange, short, exchange.

‘You know that time you called me a c**t. Did you mean it?’

‘Nah. I call everyone a c**t.’